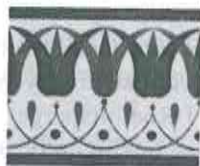


4

Listening: The Mother of all Speaking



"Speech is difficult, silence is impossible." The Chinese sage who made this profound statement hundreds of years ago knew very well the pivotal role of listening in making communication effective. We, however, generally think of listening as a passive skill. Nothing could be farther from the truth. Listening is the mother of all speaking because both the communicator and the communicatee need it to carry on communication.

Active and empathic listening is the ultimate compliment one can pay another person. Few of us do it though because it is very, very hard. In this chapter we explore the anatomy of poor listening and identify the barriers to good listening.

We need to master different types of listening to be effective communicators: selective listening, diplomatic listening, active listening, critical listening, and empathic listening. Each has a place in our communication process. Awareness is the first step towards the distant goal of excellence in listening.

There is something special about face-to-face oral communication. It is the oldest and the commonest channel of human communication. While millions of people never write to communicate, everyone uses the face-to-face channel. In a sense, it is the easiest of all the channels of communication. Even babies employ it naturally. In another sense, it is the most difficult; few of us master it. We all make a mess of it. Ability to produce words effortlessly does not make one a good oral communicator any more than ability to type words fast and correctly makes one a writer.

ACTIVE LISTENING

People often travel long distances to communicate through the face-to-face channel even when they have access to other channels. No other channel can match its depth, range, or warmth. The secret of excellence in using the face-to-face channel lies in active listening. Listening actively and attentively

is perhaps the best compliment one can pay to another human being. The listener's eye contact, facial expressions, posture, gestures, and verbal responses—questions as well as comments—can all signify unmistakably to the speaker how well he is being perceived. Several writers on oral communication point out that good listeners are perceived as good conversationalists even when they speak very little. This is not surprising because it is listening that keeps a conversation going.

In a conversation both the speaker and the listener have to listen simultaneously to each other for their communication to be effective. The speaker has to listen not only to any verbal responses but also to the non-verbal symbols displayed by the listener. Based on them the speaker has to determine from moment to moment what to say and what non-verbal symbols to display along with them. Speakers who don't care to listen to their listeners might as well talk to a wall. They cannot be good communicators however articulate and however knowledgeable they are. They can't blame their communicatees for not reconstructing their message properly.

The listener's job is an active one. He has to process the speaker's verbal and non-verbal symbols and then set up his own verbal and non-verbal symbols to let the speaker know how her message is being reconstructed. The two players influence each other and alternate their roles constantly. In other words, a speaker is also a listener; a listener is also a speaker. Face-to-face communication then is a collaborative, seesaw effort. However, to keep our discussion manageable we shall separate the speaker's role from the listener's role and focus on listening.

In *The Dance of Change*, Peter Singe says that we have to learn to listen between the words in order to get to the deeper essence of people's speech. Good listening has an impact on the speaker. He goes on to ask: "Have you ever been in the presence of someone who listens closely to you? It feels discomfiting, like being stared at. People in society are not used to living at that level of awareness..." Good listening raises the level of communication because it means that each partner takes the other seriously. While there can be various reasons for poor listening, it generally signals the low priority the listener gives either to the speaker or to her message.

Good listening is hard work. Few of us are willing to put in such hard work for communicating successfully with fellow human beings. Or we are unaware of the depth of listening we need in order to communicate well. About a half a century ago Carl R Rogers and F J Roethlisberger (1952)¹ stated: "The biggest block to personal communication is man's inability to listen intelligently, understandingly and skillfully to another person. This deficiency in the modern world is widespread and appalling." Things haven't changed much since then. The world has shrunk; our knowledge has expanded tremendously; but our general awareness about what we need in order to use the most common channel of communication effectively has not grown.

THE ANATOMY OF POOR LISTENING

Why is it that our listening is not as good as it ought to be? The answer generally offered goes like this. Our brain is capable of processing 500 to 750 words a minute while people only speak 120 to 150 words a minute. The listener uses only a part of their brain to listen; they use their brain's spare capacity to think of other things that interest them. The result is dissipation of attention, which leads eventually to poor listening.

It is true that when our listening is poor we do think of things other than what the speaker is telling us. The explanation that we use the brain's spare capacity to think of other things, however, is not quite

satisfactory because it equates a part with the whole. Face-to-face oral communication is a complex and messy affair. Words constitute just a small part of the overall communication event. Different researchers estimate the oral component of face-to-face communication to be between 15 and 25 per cent of the total. The rest consists of a wide range of non-verbal symbols. It is obviously not enough to process the small verbal component for one to reconstruct the speaker's full message reasonably accurately. The listener needs all his brainpower to process the wide range of symbols displayed by the speaker and to reconstruct her meaning. There will then be no spare capacity, as it were, in one's brain when one listens well. One can only maintain a semblance of listening to someone while thinking of other things or people. So the reason for poor listening is that one doesn't invest one's processing power adequately to cope with the job.

Partial and selective listening is, of course, all that is needed in several contexts. Imagine, for example, that you are at a railway station waiting for a friend's train to arrive. There has been some disruption in rail traffic and many trains are running late. While you are at the station, you hear dozens of announcements about the arrival and departure of trains. When you have heard, say, fifty announcements, if you are given a test to see how much information you have retained, you will not be surprised to get a low score. You are most likely to get right answers to the questions on your friend's train and on a few trains that are not relevant to you but stand out for some reason. You may have nothing more than a vague recollection of how late most of the other trains are. You will have switched off your listening as soon as you realised that a particular announcement was not about your friend's train.

This is very natural. There is absolutely no need for you to find out and store in your brain space arrival details of trains that don't concern you. You filter out as noise the information that does not interest you. In other words, you listen intently to just a part of what you hear—only the part that interests you or is relevant to you. Superficial listening is more than enough to monitor the announcements. Our body language changes dramatically when what is relevant to us enters our mind's radar screen. Our listening becomes intense. The ears struggle to disentangle the announcement from the myriad other strands of sounds we hear along with it at the railway station. The intensity weakens again when we realise that an announcement relevant to us is just a repetition and we already know what the content is.

We do the same thing with reading, too. When we get the newspaper, we don't read the whole of it with the same attentiveness. We may not even read what the editor considers to be the lead story. We may skip several pages and go straight to the sports page or classifieds. Within the sports page we may skip several items and focus on just cricket or chess. Any other approach would be wasteful.

The fast scanning of the newspaper for selecting what to read thoroughly is equivalent to the partial listening we adopt when we need nothing more than monitoring. There is, however, a big difference between reading and listening. While the reader decides what to read when and at what pace, the pace of listening is not in the listener's hands; it is controlled by the speaker. While the reader can nearly always go back to a portion of the text and read it once again or several times, the listener can't normally get back to a part of the speech she has been listening to. She can, in some contexts, ask for a repetition of a word or phrase; but when it comes a second time, there could be subtle changes in the non-verbal symbols accompanying it. In any case, it is embarrassing to keep asking the speaker to repeat; so she may be tempted to be content with what she can make of the speech.

The only choice we have as listeners is to listen or not to listen. Often we choose not to listen; we merely pretend to listen. So we fail to notice many verbal and non-verbal symbols displayed by the

speaker. We may jump to conclusions. Naturally, our reconstruction of meaning remains incomplete or becomes vastly different from the original.

CONTRIBUTORS TO POOR LISTENING

There are several factors—linguistic, physical, and psychological—that contribute to poor listening and grossly inadequate reconstruction of the speaker's meaning. Here are a few.

Inadequate Language

Poor listening may stem from the listener's weak language proficiency in general and narrow range of vocabulary in particular. Certain words a speaker uses may not make any sense to a listener. These words need not be technical or rare words. They could be simple common words used with special or local meanings attached to them. They could be in-house acronyms and other short forms that a speaker uses without realising that the particular listener may not be able to make sense of them.

Faced with words that are beyond one's range a listener may not ask for clarification because he may be afraid or shy, or because he doesn't get an opportunity, as in a public speaking context. Or he may feel that he shouldn't ask because he is expected to know them. Asking for word meanings may dent the image he may have created in the speaker or the rest of the audience. Whatever the reason, the ultimate result is poor listening.

It is also possible that the words a speaker uses may give the listener a valid meaning that is different from what is intended by the speaker. An employer may have gross salary in mind when she quotes compensation figures to a job seeker. For the job seeker, 'salary' may be what he can take home. He may not even be aware of various mandatory cuts, including income tax deducted at source by the employer. When a listener thinks he knows the meaning of a word, he may not ask for clarification. He may draw a wrong picture with misplaced confidence. Later, when there is a dispute on exactly what was said, the listener may even recall with conviction that the speaker had specifically said "net salary" or "take home pay". That is the way the word 'salary' is registered in his mind.

While we normally associate listening with spoken words and phrases, we ought to include non-verbal symbols—listening between words—also in its ambit. Inadequate familiarity with regional conventions and cultural values also may stand in the way of full and active listening because the listener may miss many of the non-verbal symbols accompanying the spoken words.

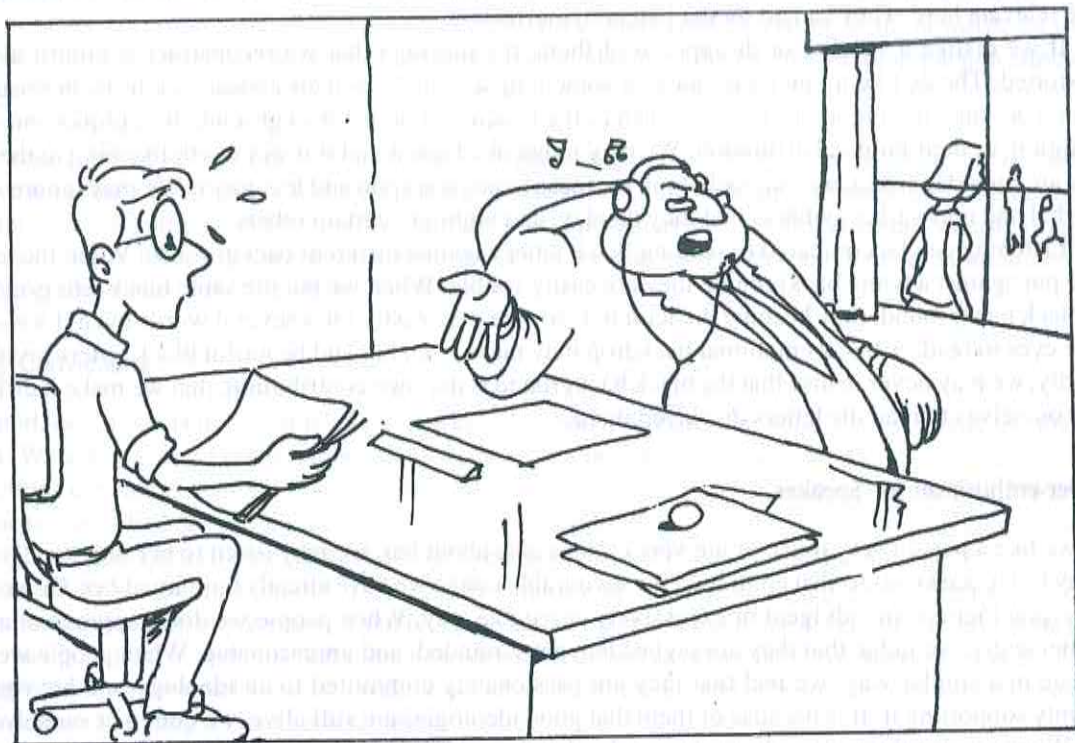
Difficult Physical Conditions

Poor listening can stem from difficult conditions in which one has to listen. Public places and shop floors of manufacturing units can be so noisy that in spite of straining one's ears one may mishear words or not hear them well enough to process them. Not wanting to embarrass the speaker by repeatedly asking to be louder, slower, or clearer, the listener may settle for a meaning that makes sense to him. Or he may give up mentally while pretending to be listening. This is especially true when the speaker is of an intimidatingly high status. A listener may have no choice about the context in which he has to listen. If he has a choice and yet is too lazy to move out of poor physical settings, he is guilty of choosing to be a poor listener.

Non-serious Listening

Some listeners allow themselves to be distracted. They don't take listening seriously enough to devote their full attention to it. They may try to combine several activities such as flipping through a book, looking for a letter in a file, signing documents, arranging papers on the desk, and so on while listening to someone. Rarely would a listener do justice to the speaker with such active courting of distractions.

The temptation to combine listening with other activities is particularly strong when people speak on the phone. They feel that the energy they save by not having to look at the speaker could be invested in doing other things. They are inviting trouble. Because the words on the phone line come with far fewer non-verbal symbols than the face-to-face ones, the listener should do just the opposite: concentrate on the words.



"Go on. I am listening."

For a different set of reasons, it is not a good idea to indulge in partial listening while one is face-to-face with the speaker. It can demoralise her. She may justifiably feel snubbed. Children are so sensitive to this kind of listening that they often make their parents turn their faces towards them and look at them when they speak.

Lack of Interest

If we are not interested in the speaker or the message, it is obvious that we will miss most of the symbols they display. Isn't it a common experience that a couple of hours after watching a news bulletin we

remember the number of runs scored or wickets lost by our cricket team but not vital numbers pertaining to national economy or education given in the lead story. Some of us could have exactly the opposite experience. We may remember political, economic, or educational data but not those related to sports. The reason is that we listen carefully and lovingly to what interests us; we tend to pay little more than partial attention to the rest.

Antipathy Towards Speaker

The biggest cause of poor listening has little to do with language or physical settings. It consists of the listener's psychological barriers. They are treacherous because the listener neither sees them nor recognises them as barriers even when seen. The seven communication roadblocks we discussed in Chapter 2 are relevant here. They can all render listening ineffective.

If we dislike a speaker or disapprove of them, the message that we reconstruct is almost always distorted. The dislike might be because of something as simple as their appearance or mannerisms. It could be something more deep-seated such as their socio-economic background, their profession, their religion, or their political affiliation. We may judge in advance that it is not worth listening to them. If we are forced to listen, we may only look for ideas to pounce upon and tear apart. We may ignore some verbal and non-verbal symbols that they display, and highlight certain others.

Listening can be compared to reading black letters against different backgrounds. When the letters are put against a white background, they are easily visible. When we put the same black letters against a black background, they become difficult to read. We may easily miss several words even if we strain our eyes to read. A black emotional backdrop may make even big and beautiful black letters invisible. Sadly, we may never realise that the black background is our own contribution, that we make it difficult for ourselves to read the letters displayed there.

Over-enthusiasm for Speaker

If we like a person very much or are very enthusiastic about her, we may listen to her uncritically. We may fail to see symbols that contradict the favourable image we have already built up of her. Or we may interpret them in an indulgent or excessively charitable way. When people we don't approve of argue vehemently, we judge that they are pigheaded, petty-minded, and unreasonable. When people we like argue in a similar way, we feel that they are passionately committed to an ideology and are right in firmly supporting it. It is because of them that good ideologies are still alive, we convince ourselves.

When my daughter comes home from school and complains about a teacher or a classmate, I tend to take it at face value. I don't see any inconsistencies in what she tells me. I don't look for them either. Even if I ask the teacher or the classmate concerned for their version, I am not serious about their answer. I have already arrived at a conclusion based on my daughter's account. I don't need to listen to them.

This kind of discriminatory listening is the norm rather than the exception. It is rarely that we listen objectively. Nearly four centuries ago Blaise Pascal was referring to manifestations of this feature when he said, "We are usually convinced more easily by reasons we have found ourselves than those which have occurred to others."

Lack of Confidence

If we decide in advance that we will not be able to make sense of what the other person is going to say, our listening suffers. We give up without a fight. We then sit and hear words, but not process anything. This is particularly common in classrooms where complex issues are discussed or concepts explained. Some students start with the assumption that they will not be able to cope. And they fulfil their prophecy. They are being unfair to themselves and the speakers.

Impatience

Impatience is born out of overconfidence. Before they hear out the speaker some listeners assume that they know what is coming. They find the speaker too slow. They tend, therefore, to fill in words for the speaker. They can't wait for the speaker to finish. This tendency of the listener to jump the gun annoys most speakers. Some of them may change the message at the last moment just to spite the listener who cuts in to complete what she has been trying to say.

Another form of impatience is to plan one's response while pretending to be listening to what the speaker is saying. The impatient listener guesses too soon what the speaker is going to say, and on that assumption, concentrates on formulating his response. There may be a serious mismatch between the two sets of assumptions. It can be exasperating for the speaker to find that the listener is mindlessly advancing arguments that have already been rebutted.

Strong Convictions

The mind, says a wit, is like a parachute. It works only when it is open. The trouble is our minds are often closed. We are so sure of certain things that we don't see the need to reconsider them. Our beliefs and convictions can act as a shield that stops new ideas and new proofs from reaching our minds. If I am convinced that astrology is bunkum, I may pretend to be listening to you when you go on and on about how accurate many astrological predictions have been. I may insert occasional 'hmms' and 'ahas'. You may think I am listening; I am not. I am merely thinking up arguments to rebut your arguments, or counter examples to disprove you without really trying to understand you. Or, if I don't want confrontation, I may put up false symbols that indicate understanding and concurrence. You may go away thinking that you have presented your case well; that I have understood it and accepted it. You are mistaken. I haven't been listening. I have been faking it.

Such diplomatic listening may be all right when you are forced to humour the speaker who might be in a position of authority and is abusing it to secure your company. Disagreeing or presenting a different perspective might lead to either waste of time or unpleasantness. Diplomatic listening is not welcome when you are expected to listen with your full heart and mind.

Listening—The Nelson Way

Horatio Nelson, England's greatest-ever naval hero, often achieved his famous victories by acting independently of his superiors.

He lost his right eye when he was commanding the British warship, *Agamemnon*, and fighting in the Mediterranean Sea in 1793. Eight years later, he was second in command of a British attack on the Danish

fleet off Copenhagen. His superior judged that the battle was not at all going well for the British. He signalled to Nelson to break off and retreat. But Nelson was very confident that he could win. And yet he didn't want to appear to disobey orders. So he put the telescope to his blind eye and declared that he couldn't see any signals from his superior. He continued the fight and, of course, won the battle.

Strong convictions and preconceived notions based on our prior experience can be an invisible barrier to interpersonal and intra-organisational listening. In Stephen Covey's² words, we are reading our "autobiography into other people's lives" rather than listening to them from their own framework, through their own paradigm. As a result, we fail to understand them although we believe we do.

Strong disagreements generally bring out the worst types of listening in us. It is not at all uncommon to see two people speaking to each other simultaneously. Both speak loudly and excitedly hoping to silence the other with their superior arguments delivered non-stop. Each is convinced that he is right and the other wrong. So neither finds it necessary to listen to the other. The arguments get heated. If one withdraws after a while, it is not because he accepts the other's view, but because he feels that the other is so irrational there is no point in continuing the argument.

We might think that the more intelligent among us are better at listening than the less intelligent ones. But that is not true. The ability to listen is not like the ability to grasp or phenomenalism the principle of relativity. In theory, the more intelligent ones are perhaps capable of deeper concentration, better listening, and quicker grasping. How well they listen, however, and what they get out of it, depend on their attitude. They will be no better than their less intelligent brothers and sisters if their attitude is obstructive.

THE ANATOMY OF POOR SPEAKING

Poor speakers are primarily poor listeners. They are unable or unwilling to listen to their listeners and modify their speech accordingly. They tend to blame the listeners for the inevitable failures in communication. Poor managers, poor negotiators, poor interviewers, and poor teachers are almost invariably poor listeners, and as a result, poor speakers.

Poor speaking manifests itself in some of the following ways.

Little or No Planning

For a friendly chat with someone one knows well, no planning may be needed. That the two come together and that a friendly exchange takes place may be enough. The contents of the conversation are generally of little consequence. The expectations on both sides are low. Expectations there are all the same. If one of them is just back from a vacation abroad or recovered from a serious illness or changed her hairstyle, she would expect questions on it. If there is no question, she may feel upset because it indicates that the other person is not interested enough in what affects her.

If there is a change in any aspect of this somewhat easy configuration, planning is needed to ensure success. The depth of planning will vary depending on the type of challenge involved. It may, in some cases, be a simple fixing of one's objectives; in some other cases, the speaker may need strategic planning, especially when negotiations or major efforts at persuasion are required. Even between friends and

couples, there may be hypersensitive areas where one needs to tread with caution because any step could be risky. One may need to plan one's moves thoroughly to avoid pitfalls.

A speaker's planning involves getting answers to several questions about the listener and shaping one's strategy accordingly. Clear and precisely worded answers may not be needed. But the speaker should have a good idea of what answers he would get to questions such as the following.

- What kind of person is my listener?
- How much does she know of the topic I am going to talk on?
- What is her attitude to it?
- How sensitive is she in general and in particular to the topic I want to talk about?
- What is her general approach to life?
- What is (likely to be) her attitude towards me?
- What is my objective in talking to her? Is my objective reasonable?
- What difficulty might she have in understanding my position?
- What might prompt her to support my position?
- What if she doesn't accept my position?
- What might be her counter-arguments?
- Would I accept my position if I were in her shoes?
- What kind of arguments might she find easier to accept?

These are far from exhaustive. Besides, we may not get precise answers to all such questions on all occasions. However, if we go into a dialogue without any clue to what the answers are likely to be, we shouldn't expect to be successful in communicating. If we keep getting surprising responses or totally unexpected follow-up action from our listeners, we know where to look for reasons.

Insensitivity to the Listener and the Context

Speaking to another person requires deft moves and countermoves. It is a delicate balancing act. A speaker has to monitor the feedback from the listener and keep adjusting her symbols accordingly. The trouble is that the feedback may not be open and unambiguous. It could be subtle and difficult to size up. It could be unpredictable. It could be misleading. Or it could be simple and straightforward. We should expect the feedback to be subtle rather than plain. No one likes to be an open book. Each of us has built up a highly fortified private treasure house of values, desires, dreams, ambitions, and fears and frustrations. Only the owner has the key. Rarely are visitors allowed—we can't take anyone for granted.

Absence of empathy makes the speaker miss several symbols displayed by the listener. Inevitably, the speaker's judgement about what symbols to display to communicate his message goes awry. In extreme cases of apathy and antipathy the speaker may not even suspect that something is amiss. He may drive on, totally unmindful of the time bomb ticking away under the hood. If a boss is surprised by a subordinate's sudden resignation, she hasn't been listening enough. If a husband can't believe that his wife has filed for a divorce, he hasn't been listening enough to her in spite of living under the same roof. If a father or mother is taken aback that their daughter has eloped with someone, they haven't been listening enough to her. They are all like a person standing atop a smouldering volcano totally oblivious to the possibility of a violent eruption.

The context also is part of the constellation of symbols involved in communication, as we have noted in Chapter 1. Being unaware of it or ignoring it willfully also may result in poor communication. A job seeker may be so tense and nervous at an interview that he may be unable to answer easy questions; or he may give contradictory answers, or create an impression of hiding information. An empathic inter-

viewer will make him feel comfortable before asking him substantial questions about his knowledge and skills. When the best candidate for a job is not selected because the interviewer fails to gauge him or her correctly, the loss is mutual.

There is a saying that even God cannot approach a hungry man except in the form of bread. This is the essence of empathy. The speaker has to be sensitive to the needs, concerns, and aspirations of the listener if he wants to communicate effectively with her. Successful negotiators are those who understand and build around the ideas uppermost in the other party's mind. Successful peacemakers are those who recognise and take into account most of the concerns expressed as well as kept hidden by the warring parties. Successful persuaders are those who accurately identify what touches the hearts of the buyers of goods, services, and ideas. All these practise "empathic listening", to borrow an expression from Stephen Covey.

Use of Inappropriate Verbal Symbols

Words, we have seen, play only a small role in face-to-face communication; it is dominated by non-verbal symbols. But just as the tiny flame from a small matchstick can start a major fire, an ill-chosen word can cause a major disaster in human relations. Words can hide meaning; words can bare meaning. Words can hurt; words can heal. Choice of words may, therefore, be critical especially because words have a certain definability and recordability that non-verbal symbols have not yet achieved. There can be disputes about how a word was said or under what conditions it was said. However, once a word is uttered, that fact can't be disputed.

One day in March 2000 a debate in the Andhra Pradesh Assembly was held up for quite some time because several members objected to an expression used by a member. He had asked whether "the government was wearing bangles" while referring to the inept handling of a problem. Members were incensed at the implied prejudice against women. The user of the phrase said that he was merely using a common expression in Telugu. Little did he realise how sensitive people had become to chauvinistic expressions. He had to withdraw the expression.

A speaker has to fathom the depth of her listener's vocabulary and play within it if she wants to be effective. There are words a speaker may not use when communicating with listeners who do not share her linguistic, social, political or professional background. Slang, jargon, acronyms, and obscure idioms fall in this category. Many poor speakers are guilty of using words that do not make any sense to their listeners. No word is right if it is not appropriate to the listener. An insensitive speaker who uses expressions that don't make sense to her listener is asking for trouble. Or, she doesn't care whether her listener understands her or not.

Some speakers are so lazy that they use very vague expressions where precise ones are called for. When a speaker asks someone to "do the needful", he should realise that it is capable of wide interpretation. Vague expressions are, of course, all right where precise interpretations are unnecessary. As the cat tells Alice in Lewis Carroll's *Alice in Wonderland*, if you are not particular where you want to get, it doesn't matter which way you go. If it did not matter whether one got a report in ten days or fifteen days, one could justifiably tell her subordinate to get it ready "in the next few days". It, however, is inadequate and inappropriate if she wanted it in, say, two or three days.

Pace of speech is another factor that a speaker ought to monitor. Very slow delivery can irritate and

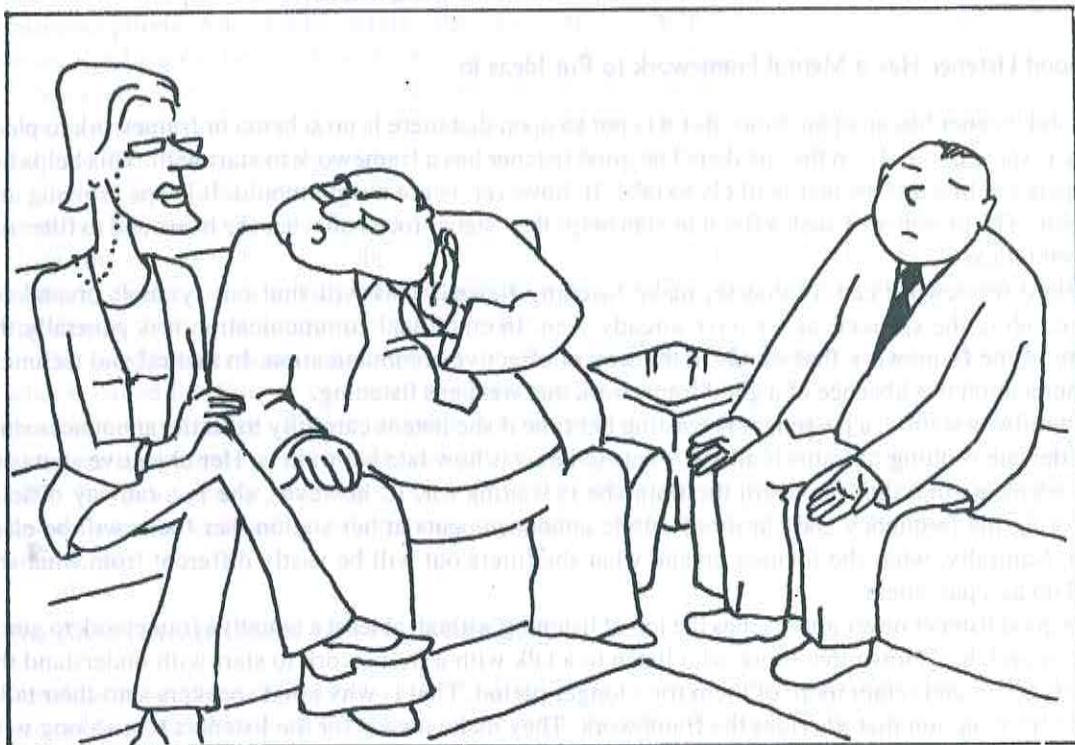
well above that of the listener. The listener may be so overawed that he may not ask the speaker to go slow or repeat something. The message the listener reconstructs is unlikely to be adequate, to say the least.

In a multilingual situation the choice of the language itself can be critical. A speaker may be so insensitive that he may choose a language that is comfortable for himself but opaque to the listener. I recall with embarrassment a recent incident at my work place. I wanted a peon to do something for me. So I gave him detailed instructions—in English. He said “yes sir”, and disappeared. About fifteen minutes later another peon came to me and asked me what I wanted done. I was furious. I merely directed him to send me the first peon. He came, sheepishly. I asked him why he hadn’t carried out my instructions. “Sorry sir,” he said (in Hindi) after a long, painful pause, “I don’t understand English.” Then I wanted to know why he hadn’t told me so. He didn’t say anything. He just stood with his head down.

On reflection I realised that it was I who was at fault. Perhaps he was too scared to tell me that I should switch to Hindi or Telugu. Or he didn’t want to spoil the impression I had of his linguistic accomplishments. Or he thought he understood, but when he started to carry out my instruction he realised he wanted greater clarity. Whatever his reason, I was the foolish one. I should have checked if he could follow English comfortably. On that day I learned a lesson on listening to the listener.

Use of Inappropriate Non-verbal Symbols

Poor speakers tend to be unaware of the consequences of the non-verbal symbols that they display. They feel that the words they use are enough. A boss who asks a subordinate with a personal problem to sit in



“This Japanese guy said he was trying to concentrate. But I can hear him snore.”

the crowded company canteen and discuss it with him is unlikely to convince her that he cares about her problem or about her self-esteem. When a boss who regularly comes late to office talks about punctuality, none of his subordinates may take him seriously. They may treat his words as just that—words.

Many job seekers spoil their chances of being hired in spite of having all the qualifications needed because of the clothes they wear to the interview. Irrespective of whether the interviewers are men or women, a woman applicant for a job jeopardises her chances of being interviewed as a professional if her dress accentuates her femininity rather than her professionalism. Some interviewees walk in in casuals; they are treated as casual visitors, not serious job-seekers.

Cross-cultural situations are a minefield for communicators as we have seen in Chapter 3. Non-verbal symbols may have vastly different meanings for different cultures. Displaying them without trying to find out what they mean in other cultures can lead to serious misunderstanding. Something as simple and routine as a handshake can cause offense or at least shocked disbelief in some cultures. Arriving late by a few minutes to a business meeting or an interview might be quite acceptable in some cultures and totally unacceptable in others. A poor speaker is not sensitive enough to the meanings of the non-verbal symbols he displays or he observes. In short, a poor speaker is a poor listener.

THE GOOD LISTENER

Good listening is active, empathic listening. And that is hard work. But because it is the cornerstone of all good communication let's take a look at the profile of the good listener.

The Good Listener Has a Mental Framework to Put Ideas in

The good listener has an open mind. But it is not so open that there is no schema or framework to place the ideas she receives from the speaker. The good listener has a framework to start with. This helps her anticipate the line the speaker is likely to take. It, however, is not a rigid mould. It keeps growing and changing. The presence of such a flexible plan helps the listener focus on what she hears and to filter out irrelevant ideas.

A rigid framework can, of course, make listening flawed. This will shut out symbols crucial for understanding the speaker, as we have already seen. In emotional communication it is generally the rigidity of the framework that stands in the way of effective communication. In neutral and technical communication it is absence of a good framework that weakens listening.

At a railway station, a passenger is wasting her time if she listens carefully to all the announcements about the late running of trains if all she wants to know is how late her train is. Her objective shuts out announcements that don't concern the train she is waiting for. If, however, she is a railway official monitoring the frequency and clarity of public announcements at her station, her focus will be elsewhere. Naturally, what she focuses on and what she filters out will be vastly different from what she would do as a passenger.

The good listener never approaches the job of listening without at least a tentative framework to guide her. Research has shown that those who listen to a talk with a framework to start with understand the contents better and retain more of them for a longer period. That is why good speakers start their talks with an introduction that provides the framework. They make it easy for the listeners to go along with them. This is equally relevant to interpersonal communication.

The Good Listener Actively Engages the Ideas the Speaker Presents

In other words, the good listener is a critical listener. She sifts the ideas and weighs the evidence as she listens. She notes everything but accepts and retains only what passes her criteria. She neither accepts nor rejects the ideas uncritically. That active engagement with ideas helps her focus her mind on the task of listening and improve her retention of ideas. It is because of this critical evaluation that a good listener finds no time, while listening, to wander.

If the engagement is longer than a few minutes, the good listener also quickly reviews and summarizes what she has heard so far. This reduces the burden on the memory because what she has accepted so far becomes part of a system; it does not remain disparate pieces.

There is, however, a danger in critical listening. If the criteria the listener adopts are rigid or excessively narrow, new ideas may not be accepted at all. There are occasions where the framework itself must change. Clinging to a familiar paradigm can shut out newer and perhaps more sensible ways of looking at the world. A good listener strives for a golden mean.

Critical listening is essential for good technical communication. Critical listening is called for even in interpersonal communication; but the listener has to be far more accommodative.

The Good Listener Asks Questions

The way in which an active listener shows engagement is by asking the speaker questions whenever possible. Some questions will help the speaker elaborate on underdeveloped ideas or correct certain misconceptions. Answers to certain other questions will help the listener confirm, reject or revise interim conclusions she may have arrived at.

Speakers generally welcome questions from those they speak to because questions are a sign of active listening. Irrelevant questions, of course, have precisely the opposite effect on the speaker. They may indicate that the listener has not been listening or has been far off the track.

Certain questions don't seek to enhance understanding but to pull the speaker down. These are obstructive questions. Those who ask them are like hecklers at a meeting. They don't listen. They have fixed their minds. Their only objective is to shut up the speaker. If obstructive questions come from an authority figure, it can be very difficult to cope with them. You may need additional resources either to stand up to them or strategies to neutralise them.

The good listener is also capable of holding back questions and comments if she judges that silence is what is called for. Silence can be an excellent way to listen. It helps the speaker complete his chain of thought without being influenced unduly by the listener's comments. If the speaker is oversensitive, a listener's questions and comments can act as a barrier. Silence is especially useful at the negotiating table. Revealing one's hand too soon can give the other party an undue advantage. The skilled listener knows when to keep silent, when to ask questions, what kind of questions to ask, and when to make comments.

The Good Listener Listens with Her Whole Body

Good listening is not just an aural activity. It involves the whole body. And soul, one might add! If one is preoccupied with unrelated things while listening, except in communication of the routine and inconsequential kind, the reconstruction of the message is bound to be affected badly. Moreover, denied continuous feedback, the speaker will not know how to proceed, what to say, what to avoid. He will not know

whether the message he is sending is being reconstructed well, accepted, or rejected. The feedback can be in the eyes, in facial expressions, and in posture. Sitting up (rather than sitting back) and maintaining eye contact with the speaker are excellent ways of shutting out distractions and focussing on the message.

If there is pleasure on the listener's face, the speaker is encouraged to speak. Good, animated listeners are in great demand. They bring out the best in speakers. If you listen with your whole body and soul, you can also resist distractions that distort the message that you are reconstructing.

It is not possible to listen fully and actively if the mind is full of worries and tensions. The good listener, therefore, clears her mind of such distractions and focuses on the message sent by the speaker. When she is in control, the good listener chooses a suitable place that is free from intrusions, interruptions, and distractions. It is impossible to combine good quality listening with driving through heavy traffic or eating at a busy, noisy restaurant. The good listener seeks quiet and privacy so that nothing disturbs the process of reconstructing messages from the speaker's verbal and non-verbal symbols.

The Good Listener Does Not Judge Prematurely

The good listener resists passing judgement until she has found enough evidence. Many poor listeners jump to conclusions long before the speaker has completed sending his message. Kevin J Murphy³ points out that some poor listeners try to finish statements for the slow deliberate speakers in the interest of saving time. This is risky. And annoying to the speaker. James A Morris⁴ refers to this "second guessing", and adds that those who interrupt the speaker and complete the thought for him insult him. Morris goes on to state (p. 26): "Sought-after conversationalists listen attentively; only amateurs play the second guessing game."

The trouble with jumping to conclusions is that it closes the listener's mind. Then it neither notices nor accommodates other symbols that contradict or challenge the conclusion she has built up. The poor listener gets a wrong picture but goes on with the impression that she has been a smart, efficient listener. The good listener waits and weighs the evidence gathered. She suspends her judgement until the end because she knows that a single symbol could alter the complexion of an entire constellation.

The Good Listener Goes Beyond the Message; She Takes Interest in the Message-Sender, too

The good listener builds up a profile of the speaker while recreating his message. Perhaps a speaker keeps making sweeping and derogatory remarks about everyone else; in his eyes everyone is awful. Perhaps he holds a very low opinion of his company's leadership. Perhaps he is consistently critical about people who belong to a particular region, religion, or political party. Perhaps he is a sucker: he believes everything he hears. Perhaps he is hypocritical. Perhaps he is vain. Perhaps he tends to exaggerate everything. Perhaps he has a confused mind. Perhaps he is given to jealousy. Perhaps he is mean-minded. Perhaps he is generous. Perhaps he is very cautious when he speaks. Perhaps he has unusually detailed knowledge about someone, some place, or something. A listener may build up a tentative profile of the speaker during a single conversation or over a series of interactions. Such knowledge of the speaker helps a good listener listen critically and build up the right message. Once you know that a tree is a mango tree, you can be sure that the fruit you pick from it are mangoes even if you can't see them.

A good listener can anticipate eruptions of personal volcanoes around her even when the words she hears indicate nothing special. This is because her listening is not limited to the words. She listens to the person and the host of non-verbal clues to the real state of affairs.

Imagine that your boss, a Division Head, generally takes quick decisions. She does not consult her boss except in major policy matters. You ask her for two weeks' leave to take your elderly mother to Banaras. Suppose your boss says, "Well, you know, I ought to check with the MD before I let you go for a fortnight." With the profile of the person you have already built up you should be able to conclude that she will not support your application for leave. The words on their own merely refer to the procedure she is going to adopt. It is your understanding of her personality and style of functioning that helps you reconstruct her real meaning. She doesn't want to give you leave, but she doesn't want to appear to refuse you leave. If you are a good listener you will be able to ask her whether or not she will support your application. She will then have to give a clear answer one way or other.

The Good Listener Sincerely Seeks to Understand

The good listener does not fake listening. Good listening is not a matter of technique; it is a way of life. One can fake listening responses but not listening reflexes. As the entire body is involved in listening, some part or other will betray the lack of genuine interest. It could be the roving eyes; it could be the shuffling feet; it could be the restless fingers; it could be failure to grasp or remember something very small but important.

The good listener is an "empathic listener", to go back to Stephen Covey's expression in *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People* (p. 240). According to him, empathic listening "gets inside another person's frame of reference. You look through it, you see the world the way they see the world, you understand their paradigm, and you understand how they feel". This is how Covey summarises Habit 5 or empathic listening—*first seek to understand, then to be understood*. This is an excellent piece of advice for anyone who wants to manage well and communicate well.

LOGICAL TRAPS

Listening is a complex skill that requires multi-faculty processing. Unless we are careful, we may fall into some trap or other. We may arrive at untenable conclusions, and we may not know at all. Here are a few common logical traps.

A speaker may argue persuasively, but his argument may be based on unproved assumptions or gross generalisations. A marketing manager may, for example, argue for a pullout from the company's traditional field of operation when an MNC (multinational company) enters it because "*MNCs are ruthless operators ready to use any means—fair or foul—to beat the competition*". A bank manager may argue against advancing loans to petty traders because "*they never pay back*".

Some speakers slip in loaded words to influence the listener subtly. "It is *unpatriotic* to buy TVs and fridges from foreign companies when Indian companies not only make good stuff but also contribute to the *motherland's* economy." "Allowing the import of used cars will make India a *dirty dumping ground* for the world's *rubbish*."

Tautology (restating something and presenting it as proof) is a common trap the unwary fall into. Imagine that a person says import of goods that we can make domestically should be banned because import brings goods into the country and takes money away. There is no argument here; he merely restates the meaning of import. If he wants to argue against import of goods that we can make domestically, he should advance different reasons.

We need to check if the conclusions presented can be logically derived from the statements of fact made. Here is a statement of fact—"The Board of Directors decided unanimously to make Mr Rameswar Thakur the new Managing Director." Here is a conclusion—"Therefore he is the best person to lead the company in these troubled times." This conclusion doesn't follow at all from the fact stated. There may be other logically valid conclusions such as Mr Thakur can expect cooperation from all the Directors.

Occasionally we find speakers attributing a causal link between two events that merely take place one after another. We need to be alert to spot such links. Imagine that someone criticises the appointment of Mr Thakur as the Executive Director of Ayur Pharma Ltd because the price of the company's shares declined by 27 per cent since he took over. We need to ask—Does it follow? Are they linked causally? Could there be other factors? Could it be that the share price of the entire pharmaceutical sector has declined by 25 – 40 per cent during the same period? Could it be due to a change of government policy regarding import of drugs?

Does the speaker present *one* of the possible conclusions as the *only* possible conclusion? Let's take the following statement: "Mr Mathur willed all his properties to charities. *Therefore*, he *obviously* cared for the poor and the needy." Not really. Of course, it is possible. But it is also possible that Mr Mathur hated the members of his family so much that he didn't want to give them anything. Willing his properties to charities was perhaps his way of denying them to his own family.

A common tactic used by some speakers is to reduce the opposition's idea to absurdity. Imagine that you suggest installation of tea/coffee vending machines from which all employees can take tea or coffee free whenever they want rather than wait for the canteen boy to supply it at fixed hours. If the opposition draws a picture of everyone abandoning their cubicles and hanging around the vending machines throughout the day downing dozens of cups of free tea or coffee and doing no work at all, you know they are reducing your suggestion to absurd levels. You need to counter it rather than accept it meekly.

CONCLUSION

We need to master different types of listening to be effective communicators: selective listening, diplomatic listening, active listening, critical listening, and empathic listening. Each has a place in our communication process. Using one type of listening when a different type is called for creates problems. An effective communicator is comfortable with all varieties of listening and chooses the most appropriate one on each occasion.

Empathic listening is the highest form of listening, and the most difficult. In fact, it is against nature. We are basically self-centred and see the world through our own framework. To put it aside and adopt another person's framework is very hard indeed. But it guarantees success in interpersonal relations. It is not surprising then that many highly successful leaders have singled out listening as the essential managerial skill. It is the key life skill.

Looking Back

Listening is not a passive skill but an active skill that requires multi-faculty processing. Attentive, active, and empathic listening is also the best compliment one can pay someone. Because good listening is hard work, few of us master it. Good listening is the secret of the success of most leaders.

Several factors contribute to poor listening. Here are a few.

- Inadequate proficiency in the language being used
- Difficult physical conditions over which one has no control
- Lack of interest in the speaker or the topic
- Extending selective listening to unsuitable areas
- Presence of distracters
- Antipathy towards the speaker
- Over-enthusiasm for the speaker or idea leading to blind acceptance
- Lack of confidence in one's ability to make sense of what is being communicated
- Overconfidence leading to carelessness
- Strong convictions blocking receptivity to new ideas

One cannot be a good speaker without being a good listener. Listening *is* the mother of all speaking. In order to speak and communicate well we have to invest a bit in planning what to say and how. If we are not sensitive to the listener and do not choose our verbal and non-verbal symbols carefully, we will not get through to our communicatees well.

The good listener starts with a mental framework to put ideas in but is open-minded about what the speaker says. She actively engages the ideas the speaker presents and asks him questions to indicate to him how she reconstructs his message. She listens with her whole body and takes notes if the ideas are complex. She does not judge prematurely. She goes beyond the message; she takes interest in the message-sender, too. She sincerely seeks to understand by trying to get inside the speaker's frame of reference.

There are several traps the unwary listener is likely to fall into. Here are a few: The speaker's argument may be based on unproved assumptions or gross generalisations. He may slip in loaded words. He may use tautology as if it were proof. He may present conclusions that cannot be derived from the facts stated or attribute a causal link between two events that merely take place one after another. The speaker may present one of the possible conclusions as the *only* possible conclusion. He may also stretch the proposition's idea to absurdity. None of these may be deliberate; but a listener has to be alert.

References

1. Carl R Rogers and F L Roethlisberger "Barriers and Gateways to Communication," *Harvard Business Review*, July – August 1952, p. 34.
2. Stephen Covey, *The Seven Habits of Highly Effective People*, p. 239. London: Simon and Schuster.
3. Kevin J Murphy (1987), *Management by Effective Listening*, p.37. New York: Bantam.
4. James A Morris (1976), *The Art of Conversation*, p. 26. London: Simon & Schuster.

Additional Resources

1. Burley-Allen, Madelyn (1982), *Listening: The Forgotten Skill*, New York: Wiley.
2. Clark, Colin (1999), *How to give effective business briefings; effective techniques for relaying information...feedback from employees*, London: Kogan Page.
3. Poertner, S and K M Miller, (1999), *Art of giving and receiving feedback*, Iowa: American Media Publishing.